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The Power of R&B in Etta James *At Last!*

From joy to heartache, music has a way of expressing feelings in a way nothing else seems to and Etta James' album *At Last!* (1960) serves as a perfect testament, taking you through a full emotional journey. On first listen, her songs instantly captivated me, and I found myself connecting to a story I had never experienced. Now I consider myself a firm listener of pop, however this album was eye-opening to the world of R&B, jazz, and the blues. What particularly caught my interest is the way James can transform pop into a blend of all these genres yet keep the music elegant and simple. From the very first beat to the last, James finds a way to keep the audience on their toes.

While James' voice is enough to captivate, understanding her album's intention gives it a whole new meaning. James first started singing and writing music for the world as a teenager. Her early music consisted of blues and jazz, genres she felt helped her express teenage rebellion. In this era, she continued to write many songs in these genres for a production company and began to explore rock and roll as well. However, as she began writing her debut album *At Last!* she shifted from edgy, teenage music to a more elegant, sophisticated style as she matured (Women in Rock and Roll's First Wave). The album's backstory is expressed in each song, depicting love in a mature, vulnerable perspective akin to the conclusion of a coming-of-age movie.

The elegance of this album is apparent from its first notes, in “Anything to Say You’re Mine,” James reveals her powerful vocals. Whether it be in the chorus or in the gaps between it, her vocals stretch out, and fill your surroundings. Simply, the strength of the song allows you to imagine it as if she was singing it in front of you live. Belting lines like “my heart cries” with the blend of slow instrumentals, this song evokes longing and yearning that set the stage for the album’s theme of “all-consuming” love. The next song, “My Dearest Darling”, continues the same theme but James’ powerful vocals do not take a break. With a play on the instrumentals, she creates a bouncy and whimsical sound, that sounds as if it were teasing you. And this sound is only enriched with her incredible vocal prowess. While listening to this album it's hard to ignore the amount of passion in each line she sings, as if her voice were a radiant spotlight cutting through the darkness. To truly appreciate her music is to simply sit with your headphones on and let yourself be drawn into her voice.

After the first two songs, the album shifts themes as the next song, “Trust in Me”, uses slow instrumentals and mellow vocals, taking a shift from the blues tone it had to incorporate jazz tunes. Though it features a different genre, the song seamlessly transitions from the vulnerability of the previous songs yet continues to maintain the powerful and lively feeling of the album. While her vocals bring out the passion in her music, the sheer genius of her lyrics cannot be underestimated. In this song, she finds a way to sing the meaning of “love is a sure thing” more sweetly than the phrase itself, comparing her love to the presence of the moon up above and the birds in the sky. This theme is continued in the next song, “A Sunday Kind of Love”, which features a steady beat. The slow tempo of the song makes it sound almost as effortless as the “Sunday kind of love” she sings about. While it’s not my favorite track because of its slower pace compared to the album’s high tempo start, James’ perfectly illustrates a love

that is as comforting as wrapping yourself in a fluffy blanket after a week's endeavors. It is undeniable that James' has a remarkable versatility and talent to tell stories through her music.

If the range of her vocals and her effortless tone shift wasn't enchanting enough, the rest of the album surely will be. With songs like "Tough Mary" and "I Just Want to Make Love to You," James switches tone completely, exploring a more energetic take on R&B. In both songs James features upbeat instrumentals paired with strong backup vocals that are keen to catch your attention. Unlike the previous tracks, the instrumentals break through the background, creating harmony with James' voice, achieving a genre hybrid with rock and roll elements. In these songs, the richness and sultry tone of her voice are highlighted, showcasing the versatility of her voice. From swinging tunes to energetic, foot-tapping songs, James takes you through a roller coaster of emotions and expresses every feeling of love in just a few songs.

The title track, "At Last," reverts to James' R&B core and brings the album full circle. In this song she sings, "My lonely days are over, and life is like a song," encapsulating feelings of longing and hope. The solo instrumental features almost reflect a sigh of relief, illustrating her triumph over love's yearning. While the song this is doubled with, "All I Could Do Was Cry," does not follow this theme, it uses the same genre to describe a different ending. In this song her mellow tone represents a miserable feeling instead as she belts "She was standing there with my man." These songs could have had a greater impact placed at the album's conclusion, by reverting to the original genre and giving emotional closure. However, arranging them consecutively in the track list proved to be an effective choice. The way these songs use a similar sound but tell a completely different story once again reflects James' talent in storytelling with her lyrics and voice.

One pattern that is apparent while listening to this album is that James pairs songs into two for each genre shift. She does this for the last two songs, “Stormy Weather” and “Girl of My Dreams” too. While these songs continue the slower pace of the previous two songs, they focus more on elements of soul and jazz music. James’ powerful and dynamic voice paired with the background harmonies showcase soul music influences and express the theme of longing. In “Stormy Weather” her lyrical talent comes into play with descriptive lines like “keep raining all the time”. These metaphors, alike to those in “At Last” and “Sunday Kind of Love”, create the emotional depth in her music allowing the audience to live the feelings she sings about.

Throughout *At Last!*, James succeeds in going from tender, longing ballads to energetic, passionate tunes, keeping her audience engaged for every second. And regardless of the genre, she shows her voice authentically and vulnerably, making the listening experience feel almost personal. While I consider myself new to the genre of blues, jazz, and even R&B, anything other than pop unfortunately, I would say this record finds a way to perfectly encompass the essence of each genre. The pure emotion of each song and the power of her voice prove why *At Last!* remains an icon of rhythm and blues music for generations to come.

Works Cited

Women in Rock & Roll's First Wave, 12 Jan. 2019,
www.womeninrockproject.org/reference/james-etta/. Accessed 30 Oct. 2023.

